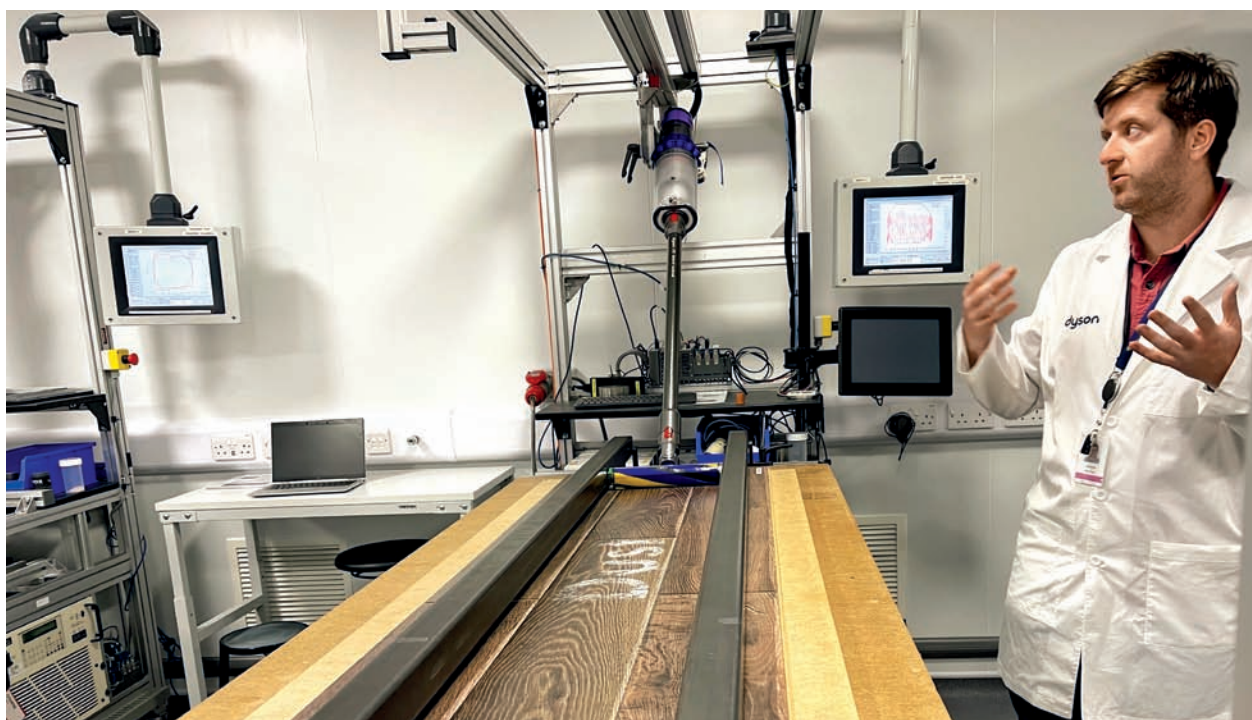




AN EYE FOR DETAIL Engineers at Dyson pay attention to the smallest of details—the kind of stuff most people would ignore

first wearable device. It comes with a two-stage air purification system in the headphones itself, which can filter out the polluted air surrounding you and in turn provide you with purified air to breathe. Unlike other face masks, this device has a visor that doesn't touch your nose or mouth and magnetically clasps onto the headphones.

Music sounds great on the Zone, and it is comfortable to wear, while the air blown onto the nose and mouth feels a lot like the air circulated on an aircraft. But it would be interesting to see whether a product like this would work in Indian cities where AQI levels are notoriously high (in triple digits) for a large part of the year. Also, Dyson products aren't known to be affordable and a pair of noise cancelling headphones by a company like Apple, without air purification capabilities, already costs upwards of ₹66,000. So, pricing will be key if the company were to launch the Zone in India. That said, James Dyson is confident that this is a product made for the Indian market.

As he excitedly demonstrates the product, the founder says no one's seen anything like this before.

“Walking on the streets or sitting on a train or a subway or bus, you're breathing in all those traffic fumes and tar dust and whatever's going on around. And this is a way to have clean air and music, and not be affected by your environment. So, that's an example of a product which was very much developed with India in mind.”

MAKE IN INDIA?

James Dyson accepts that Dyson is a very different company from what it was 22 years ago when its market was substantially in Britain. He says it would be “arrogant” to think that products for Asia and the region could be developed only from the labs in the UK. In 2019, the company faced a lot of criticism for moving its global HQ to Singapore, especially since James Dyson is known to be an outspoken Brexiter and despite pushing for Britain to leave the EU, the company's legal entity was moved to Singapore in order to “future-proof” the business. A lot of the production happens in Malaysia. Although the company was originally a British success story, it is now perceived as

a global tech company with a strong focus on Asian markets.

Dyson has been in India for around four years and has pumped in nearly £100 million into the India business. At present, the company only sells in India via Dyson demo stores and its partnerships with other electronics sellers. But James Dyson says the company is not averse to manufacturing in India. “I can't say yes, but it [Make in India] is very much on the cards. It's a really interesting and important market for us for lots of reasons.”

The Indian concept of “jugaad” or frugal innovation, usually piques the interest of most India watchers. But frugal innovation isn't a new concept for James Dyson. He says with a chuckle that his engineers at D9 are familiar with the concept—only they call it “lean engineering”. Sharing this priceless piece of information, James Dyson says goodbye, as I head back to the oldest inn in England to ruminate over Dyson's future prospects in a land thousands of miles away. **BT**

@aayush_a6

The author was in Malmesbury at the invitation of Dyson